

tions and small-scale hobby grade use cases under one framework. We are excited about this as India has spun innovation for drone operation space while managing the fleet in the country. This best practice we hope will be followed world-wide.”

Evidently, most startups we’ve spoken to have a positive view of the new regulations even though there are a few well-placed concerns.

KEY GROWTH AREAS

When it comes to the Indian subcontinent, things don’t always work out in the same way as they do in first world countries. There’s always the need to implement a more Indian-centric solution because the needs are slightly different than the developed nations of this world. Does this hold true for the drone ecosystem? And where can drones contribute to the Indian success story?

Neel Mehta of Asteria Aerospace says, “The consumer market will dominate the RPAS market in terms of volume, but the commercial and government markets will contribute more to the value. Some of the major applications of RPAS that will drive the Indian market over the next 3-4 years will be, surveillance & security (both military & civil), construction planning/progress monitoring, GIS & Surveying (urban planning, mining, highways, railways), Industrial Inspections (oil & gas, energy, utilities) and Precision agriculture. Because of the unique security challenges in India, it is expected that the market for counter-drone solutions will also emerge as a big growth area.”

According to an industry report by DroneDeploy, there are three key markets for drones: Consumer, Commercial and Military. Their market share is 17%, 13%, and 70% respectively. Currently, the growth rate is highest for the commercial market and applications such as mapping and industrial inspections contribute the maximum revenue. In the commercial market, most value and thus revenue, is derived from services. Prasanna Shevare of Drona Aviations distils the facts. According to his studies, “the Indian market is closely following the global

trend despite the drone ban. Due to the ban on drones, a couple of things happened - import of drones was really hard. This affected the drone commercial market. Post the regulation, a good growth is expected in this market. We could expect new businesses to grow here.” He further elaborates on the effects of the ban, “Import of drone components was hard. This affected the technology advancements and also affected the fundraising in this sector. Now that regulations are in place, the local drone companies will face heavy competition from the global market. Only the startups which are globally competitive will survive. However, the military market was relatively unaffected by the drone ban.”

Amit Thokal of IdeaForge has a similar opinion regarding the Military market for drones. He says, “The Indian drone industry has been on par with the global players in terms of development and deployment of technology in their products. The Indian Defence establishment has been ahead of the curve in adopting this technology for inspection, security and surveillance applications. Having said that, we see currently underserved sectors such as agriculture, real estate, oil & gas, power and mining to be the key growth areas in the Indian market.”

A FINICKY MARKET

The framework for regulations is only one part of the solution towards catering to an extremely diverse population that’s spread across the country. However, there are a few signature characteristics of the Indian mindset. It is risk averse and price conscious.

“Due to improper knowledge, sometimes people would have unrealistic expectations from drones. Education will play a key role in the growth of the industry. Also, India is a price sensitive market, thus price could play a key role in technology adoption,” says Prasanna.

The folks over at Asteria Aerospace also hold similar opinions, “RPAS regulation and enforcement of the same will continue to challenge the growth of the Indian commercial market. India is a risk-averse nation and it remains to be seen if the government is

able to progressively update the regulations to keep pace with technology as well as global trends.”

Mrinal Pai of Skylark highlights a key concern, “India has an vast number of unregistered drones and the CAR (Civil Aviation Requirement) does place new requirements to be implemented on the hardware side, so the threshold to shifting existing drones in operation to the meet the requirements might be a little too much for people with a small number of drones or those who are limited in scale. India also sees a shortage of trained and qualified Drone pilots with best practices delivering quality output.”

The regulations do require for the operator to request for clearance before taking off and enforcing the



Spying and blowing people up isn’t the only use case.

same would require a hardware or software lock linked to the permit. Should the operator get his flight request shot down, there wouldn’t be anything stopping him from taking off anyway. So a hardware modification is needed and that would make existing solutions expensive. You know what that means for the Indian consumer, don’t you?

THE SAFE BET - MILITARY

All the folks that we spoke to share the same opinion about the future of drones. The lack of any “ban” per-se in the military sector saw it gain quite a bit of traction in the market and subsequently, has a lot of companies vying for piece of the pie. Seeing how a promising product in the military industry can open a lot of doors, we expect to see a lot more drone startups entering the defence industry. Let’s just hope that we aren’t the ones to build SkyNet. **A**